There was virtually no activity at the group level or the company level that Ratan's restructuring process did not impact. He formed two main corporate bodies as a part of the restructuring process—the Group Executive Office (GEO) that defined and guided group-level initiatives required to implement his restructuring strategy, and the Group Corporate Centre (GCC), established some four years later, that looked mainly at future directions.

Both bodies reported to the Tata Sons board. In actuality, however, they worked as attached offices of the chairman. They served as Ratan's think-tanks, assisting him in fine-tuning policies, exercising oversight and helping in implementing new initiatives to fulfil his vision.

The GEO was established in September 1998. The immediate trigger for its creation was the 1997 McKinsey report which concluded that the Tatas lacked 'basic governance structures and processes at the apex level of the Group'. The origins of the body could, however, be traced to the 1983 Strategic Plan. Ratan had even then 'looked at something akin to the GEO except that the GEO looks at companies and that earlier thing [the GEO he had proposed in his plan] looked at businesses' as he said in an interview in 1999.

The conglomerate's 'growth, its complexion' or even its 'new businesses', were all 'fragmented and very ad hoc', Ratan lamented. The holding company lacked the organizational set-up to deal with issues at the group level. For instance, when the companies' proposals were discussed by the Tata Sons board or that of the individual companies, their viability and relevance were examined in silos. How they fitted into the overall group vision was not articulated, as primarily none truly existed. This necessitated the need for a group office. It was not designed to replace the management of the individual companies but to complement them, Ratan told the CEOs of the group companies during the AGMM in 1999.

The chairman assigned five major goals to the GEO: to achieve growth through strategic positioning of companies and mergers and acquisitions; to challenge performance parameters such as customer service standards and overheads; to become a repository and supplier, receiving and sharing knowledge, and enhance negotiating power; to leverage collective strength of brand identity; inter-company rationalization; and the development of a more robust portfolio. The GEO had four committees to deal with issues at